kulak family. Being a kulak meant not only that you possessed a certain amount of property but also that you possessed certain personality traits. According to the supposedly infallible Marxist doctrine, people's material conditions determined their social and spiritual character. Since kulaks allegedly engaged in capitalist exploitation, it was a scientific fact (according to Marxist thinking) that they were greedy, selfish and unreliable – and so were their children. Discovering that someone was a kulak ostensibly revealed something profound about their fundamental nature.

On 27 December 1929, Stalin declared that the Soviet state should seek 'the liquidation of the kulaks as a class',[89] and immediately galvanised the party and the secret police to realise that ambitious and murderous aim. Early modern European witch-hunters worked in autocratic societies that lacked modern information technology; therefore, it took them three centuries to kill fifty thousand alleged witches. In contrast, Soviet kulak hunters were working in a totalitarian society that had at its disposal technologies such as telegraphs, trains, telephones and radios – as well as a sprawling bureaucracy. They decided that two years would suffice to 'liquidate' millions of kulaks.[90]

Soviet officials began by assessing how many kulaks there must be in the USSR. Based on existing data – such as tax records, employment records and the 1926 Soviet census – they decided that kulaks constituted 3–5 per cent of the rural population.[91] On 30 January 1930, just one month after Stalin's speech, a Politburo decree translated his vague vision into a much more detailed plan of action. The decree included target numbers for the liquidation of kulaks in each major agricultural region.[92] Regional authorities then made their own estimates of the number of kulaks in each county under their jurisdiction. Eventually, specific quotas were assigned to rural soviets (local administrative units, typically comprising a handful of villages). Often, local officials inflated the numbers along the way, to prove their zeal. Each rural soviet then had to identify the stated number of kulak households in the villages under its purview. These people were expelled from their homes, and – according to the administrative category to which they belonged – resettled elsewhere, incarcerated in concentration camps or condemned to death.[93]

How exactly did Soviet officials tell who was a kulak? In some villages, local party members made a conscientious effort to identify kulaks by